

Somewhere Over The Rainbow Six

Tom Clancy's *Rainbow Six: Lockdown* (R6L) is the latest instalment of the *Rainbow Six* series. The popular tactical shooter series has long been a favourite amongst gamers. It's basically a port to the PC of a game made for consoles, but it's still a pretty good looking port.

For those of you who aren't sure why this game is called *Rainbow Six*: you play the game as a squad member of Team Rainbow, the world's best counter-terrorist unit. In *Rainbow Six: Lockdown*, you lead your men through various maps that are set in various cities across the globe, and attempt to eliminate hostile forces that are targeting the Rainbow Six elite squad. You go through levels killing the bad guys, rescuing the good ones and retrieving data and securing biochemical stashes along the way. The concept is simple: protect the world from evil!

Let's start with my first impression...

Great Graphics

I was surprised at the eye-candy! The graphics are pretty good. They're still not as good as my all time favourite (thus far) *Half-life 2*, so forget about comparisons to *Doom 3*, *Quake 4* or *F.E.A.R.*, but they're great for a tactical shooter.

The shadow effects and the lighting are nicely done and water reflections are also really cool. I played this game on an AMD Athlon 64 3200+ with 1 GB of DDR2 memory, an 80 GB SATA hard drive and an ATI Radeon X850 (128 MB) XT graphics card. I set all graphics settings to their highest possible values—the game loaded quickly and never framed once.

You should be able to do the same with any of the current generation cards—an NVIDIA 6600GT, or an ATI X850, or newer.

Bad AI

There is no AI to write home about. Enemies are stupid, even at the higher difficulty level, and your squad mates even sillier. When a member of your team faces enemy fire, even if he or she (yes, this game is not sexist) is outnumbered 10:1 he/she will continue to fight until death! Is this the famed bravado of the *Rainbow Six* clan, or is it just stupid AI, I still can't decide.

Even at the highest difficulty level, enemies can't seem to hit the side of a stationary 18-wheeler, leave alone kill me, and yet I can get in headshots (one shot kill) four out of every five tries! For those of you who have played and mastered tough FPS games, or even *Counter Strike*, this game will be a little too easy for your liking.

There are times when you sneak up behind enemies, shoot one of them, and the rest keep looking the other way—apparently deaf to have not heard the burst of sub-machine fire that I let rip from just a few feet away, and oblivious of the fact that I am carefully setting my sights between their ears. It's like those shooting ranges at fairs, where you shoot balloons or cute ducks.

No Tactics Required

Though a tactical shooter, there's no real tactics needed here. Perhaps it's slotted into this genre because you have to peep around corners. True, you'll get shot up if you're the type to go running blind around corners and into a horde of terrorists—but does anybody actually *do* that? If you're used to playing *Counter Strike*, playing R6L is like playing against a team of

